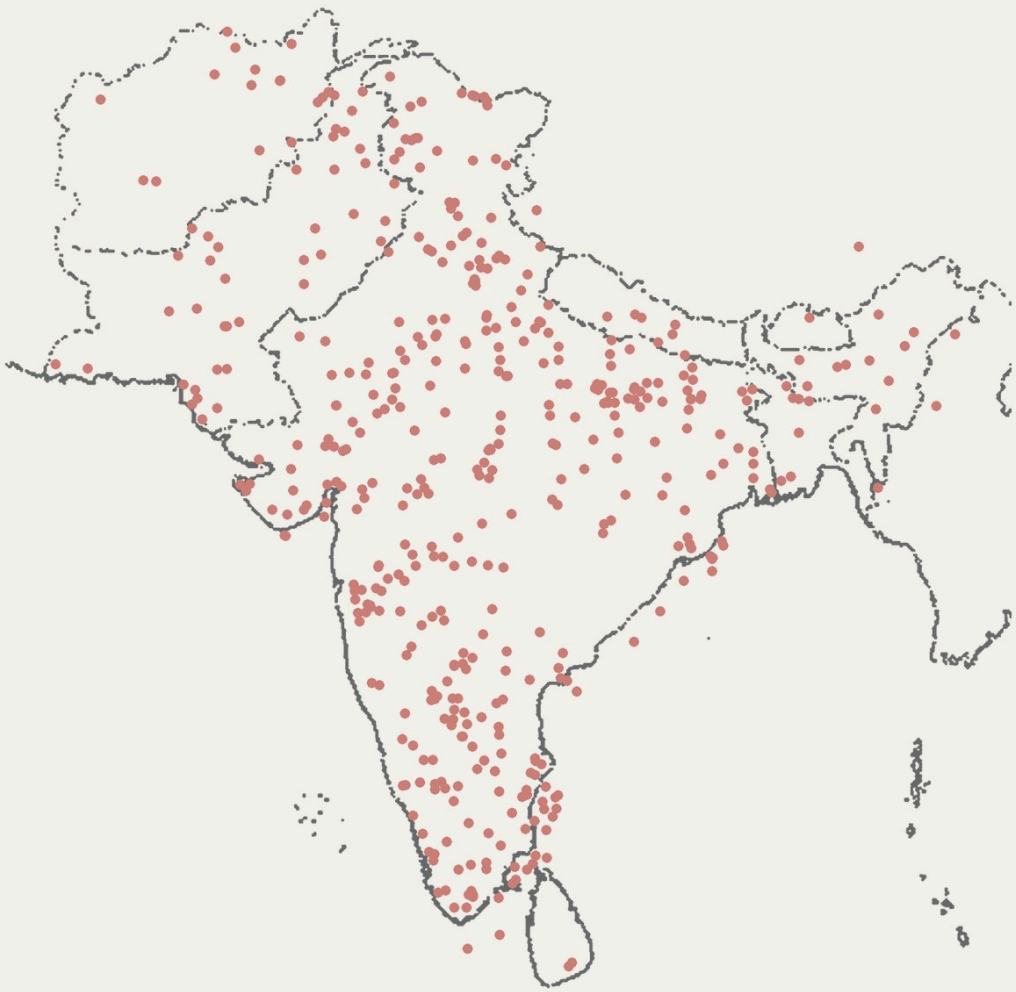
UPSC CIVIL SERVICES · HISTORY OPTIONAL

Map Entries for History Optional

A referenced atlas of the sites in the UPSC History Optional map question

480 SITES · 24 CHAPTERS



Swet Sagar

Map Entries for History Optional

A referenced atlas of the sites in the UPSC History Optional map question

Swet Sagar

FIRST EDITION · 480 SITES · OCTOBER 2026

PRACTISE ON THE MAP

Reading where a place is and placing it yourself are different skills. Test yourself on every site in this book on the interactive map — click where you think it lies and see how close you were.

upsckosha.in/maps

© 2026 Swet Sagar. All rights reserved.

First edition, October 2026.

No part of this book may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations in reviews and critical articles.

This copy is licensed for the personal use of its purchaser. Reselling it, sharing or uploading the file, or reusing its content in coaching or other commercial material without permission is prohibited.

The entries draw on the published works cited beneath each of them. The locator maps are indicative only, are not to scale, and do not purport to depict international boundaries.

Permissions, corrections and suggestions: swet.official@gmail.com

How this book is arranged

Every site the UPSC History Optional map question has drawn on, set out once, in the chapter where it belongs, with the place shown on a locator map and the answer-worthy content beneath it.

The four anchors

Each entry is written to the shape a map answer is marked on. The labels are the same in all 480 entries, so the eye learns where to look.

LOCATION	Where the site is, and anything odd about that.
PERIOD/LEVEL	Material, date, stratigraphy, excavator.
KEY FINDS	The exam-answerable content, one argument to a bullet.
SOURCES	Where the claims come from, by chapter.

The locator maps

The map beside each name carries one red dot. It answers the question the examiner is really asking — *where in India is this* — and nothing more. It is not a survey map, and distances on it should not be measured.

Positions come from the author's own marked map sheets, resolved against a gazetteer where one was available. Roughly a third remain as marked by hand and sit some tens of kilometres from truth: invisible at this scale, but the reason no entry in this edition prints a coordinate as a number.

The citations

Sources are cited by chapter rather than by page. The reference library was scanned without printed folios, so a page number would locate a passage in a scan and not in the book; a chapter is the finest locator that is honest. Works cited in full at the back.

Where part of an entry rests on the author's own notes rather than a published work, its source line says so; those parts are marked for sourcing in a later edition.

Corrections and suggestions

A misplaced dot, a wrong date, a site the exam has asked that is missing here: write to **swet.official@gmail.com**, naming the site and the source you are relying on. Corrections are folded into the next edition.

Contents

How this book is arranged iii

01 Palaeolithic Sites 43 sites 1

02 Mesolithic Sites 18 sites 23

03 Neolithic Sites 33 sites 32

04 Chalcolithic Sites 22 sites 49

05 Harappan Sites 31 sites 61

06 Megalithic Sites 14 sites 77

07 Copper Hoard and OCP Sites 8 sites 84

08 Painted Grey Ware (PGW) Sites 12 sites 88

09 Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW) Sites 20 sites 94

10 Buddhist Sites 43 sites 104

11 Art Sites 6 sites 127

12 Ashokan Inscription Sites 30 sites 130

13 Non-Ashokan Inscription Sites 11 sites 145

14 Temple Sites 40 sites 151

15 Hindu and Ajivika Cave Sites 7 sites 171

16 Jain Sites and Caves 13 sites 175

17 Cultural and Educational Centres 9 sites 182

18 Ancient Port Sites 17 sites 187

19 Ancient Capital and Trade City Sites 30 sites 196

20 Medieval City and Sufi Saint Sites 18 sites 211

21 Silk Route Sites 8 sites 220

22 Fort Sites 21 sites 224

23 Bhakti and Other Saint Sites 22 sites 235

24 Rock-cut Cave and Petroglyph Sites 4 sites 246

Works Cited 248

Index of Sites 249

Sites by State 253

CHAPTER 01

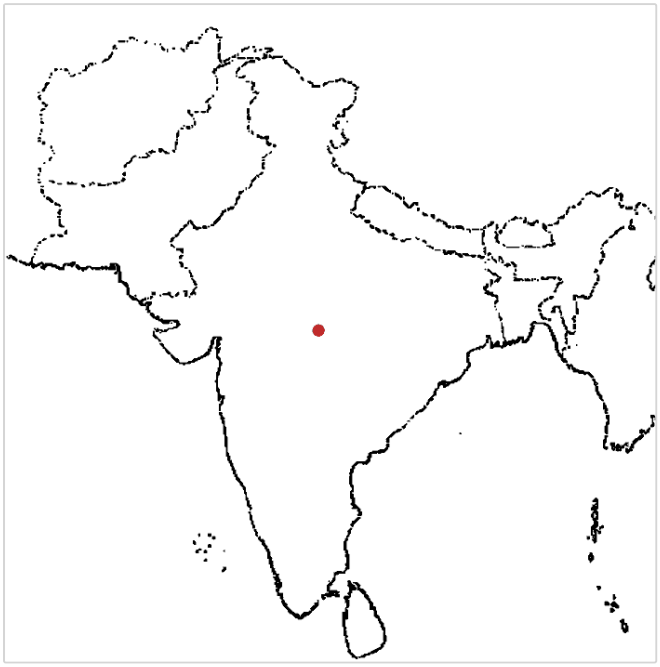
Palaeolithic Sites

43 sites

Adamgadh

Madhya Pradesh

ALSO: MESOLITHIC



LOCATION Adamgarh hill near Hoshangabad (Narmadapuram), Madhya Pradesh, in the Narmada valley on the northern edge of the Satpuras, roughly 30 km south of Bhimbetka.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower and Middle Palaeolithic in the basal levels, overlain by a rich Mesolithic horizon that passes into the Neolithic-Chalcolithic; excavated by R. V. Joshi.

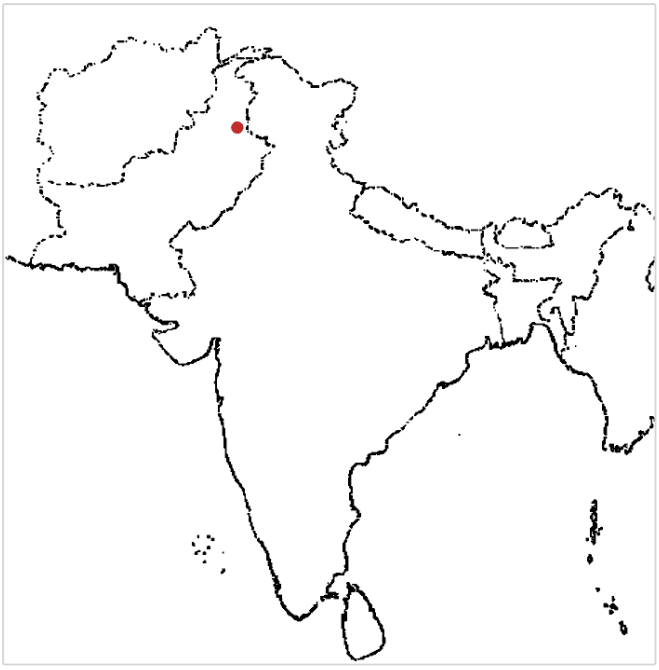
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the few sites in central India to preserve an unbroken sequence from the Palaeolithic through the Mesolithic into the food-producing stage.

- The lower and middle levels yielded Acheulian core tools of quartzite; the upper levels produced an enormous microlithic industry of chert, chalcedony, jasper and agate, with geometric microliths and potsherds dated to about 5500 BCE.
- Bones of both wild and domesticated animals were recovered, which, with Bagor in Rajasthan, gives Adamgarh the earliest evidence for the domestication of animals in the Indian part of the subcontinent, around 5000 BCE.
- The rock shelters of the hill carry paintings, linking the site to the wider Vindhyan rock art tradition of Bhimbetka.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Adiyala

Punjab



LOCATION Located in the Potwar region (West Punjab, Pakistan), lying between the Pir Panjal and Salt ranges along the Sohan (Soan) River Valley.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic (associated with the Sohanian / Sohan Valley pebble tool tradition).

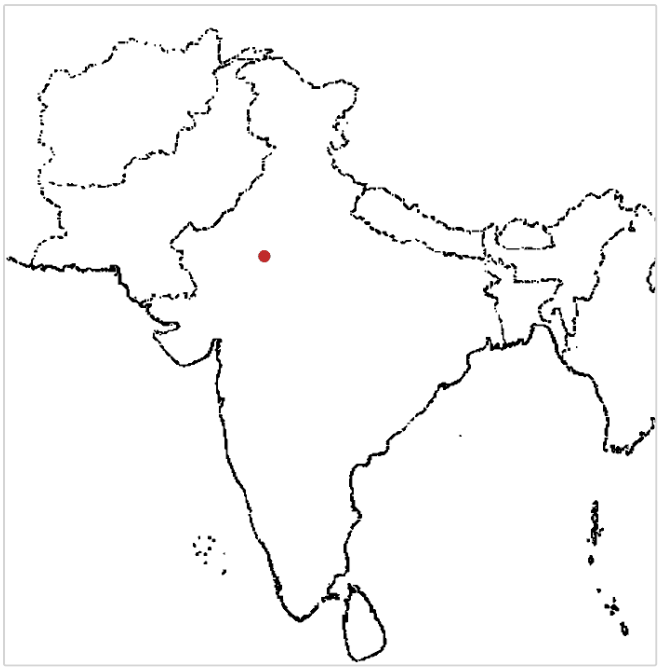
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The site yielded characteristic Lower Palaeolithic core tools, including handaxes, choppers, and edged pebble tools.

- It is one of the localities of the Soan terrace sequence surveyed by H. de Terra and T. T. Paterson in 1935, who identified five tool-bearing river terraces in the Potwar and attempted to correlate them with a four-fold glacial cycle in Kashmir; most of those correlations are no longer accepted.
- The dominance of choppers and chopping tools over handaxes is the defining trait of the Soanian, long contrasted with the Acheulian handaxe traditions of peninsular India, though sites such as Ghumarwin where the two occur together have weakened that sharp division.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (the Soan valley and the de Terra-Paterson survey; Adiyala itself and the Ghumarwin comparison are from the author's notes)*

Ajmer(Hakra Basin)

Rajasthan



LOCATION Situated in the Thar Desert region around Ajmer and the Budha Pushkar / Hokra lake basins in Rajasthan.

PERIOD/LEVEL Multi-layered sequence covering the Lower, Middle, and Upper Palaeolithic phases.

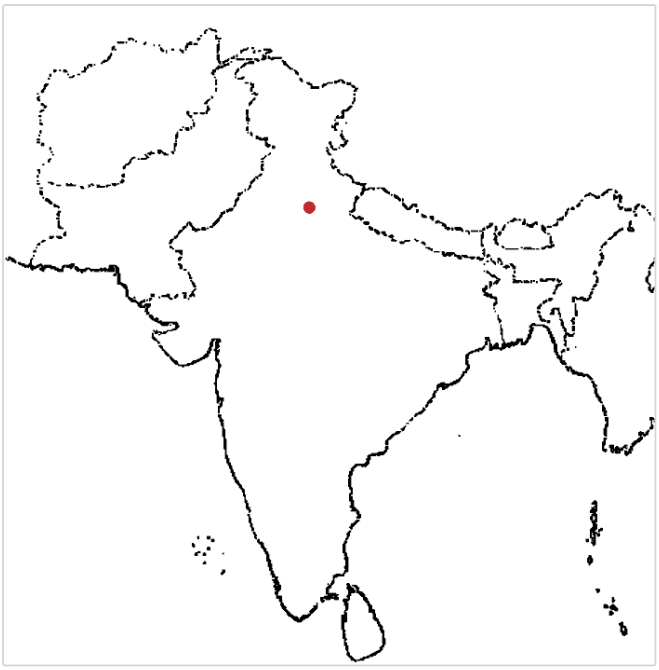
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The Budha Pushkar and Hokra basins provide a continuous sequence of prehistoric human occupation from the Lower Palaeolithic onwards.

- Excavations revealed Middle Palaeolithic working floors at Hokra and Baridhani, situated close to ancient, now dried-up freshwater lake beds.
- Small factory and camp sites in this region indicate a cooler, wetter, and more humid palaeo-environment with abundant surface water during the Middle Palaeolithic phase.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2*

Anangpur

Haryana



LOCATION Anangpur, in the Badarpur hills of the Aravalli quartzite ridge immediately south of Delhi (Faridabad district, Haryana).

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic, with both early and late Acheulian assemblages.

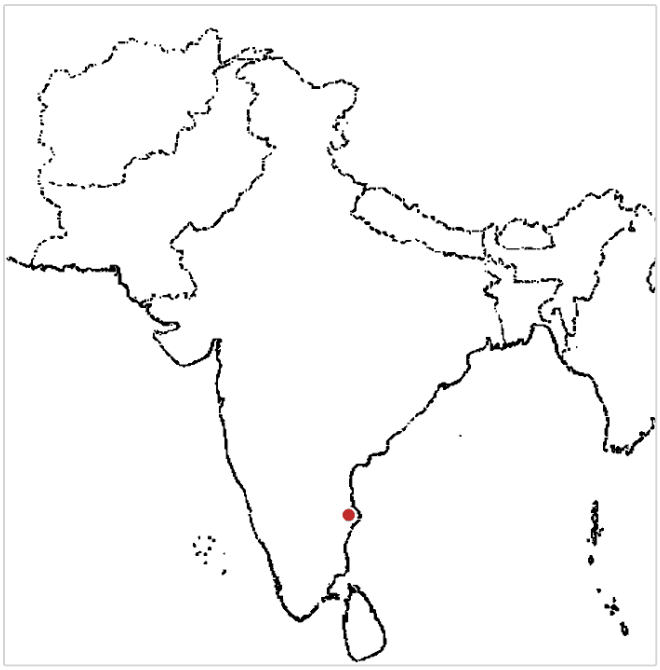
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Excavations revealed thousands of early and late Acheulian tools together with traces of several palaeo-channels of the Yamuna, marking this as a large Lower Palaeolithic habitation-cum-factory site.

- A systematic survey of south Delhi and adjoining areas by Chakrabarti and Lahiri (1986) identified 43 stone age sites ranging from the Lower Palaeolithic to the microlithic, including finds on the Delhi Ridge near Delhi University and a late Acheulian handaxe on the JNU campus in 1983.
- The site is a standard illustration that stone age sites are not remote curiosities but lie under areas that are today densely urbanised.
- The same village later carried early medieval fortifications and a stone masonry dam associated with the Tomara king Anangapala, giving the place its name.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Attirapakkam

Tamil Nadu



LOCATION Attirampakkam, in the Kortallayar river basin, Tiruvallur district, about 60 km north-west of Chennai, Tamil Nadu.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic in sequence, with a break in occupation after the Middle Palaeolithic; discovered in 1863 and excavated off and on since, most recently by Shanti Pappu and Kumar Akhilesh.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the richest and best-dated Palaeolithic sites in India, whose Acheulian levels have been placed at roughly 1.5 million years BP by cosmogenic burial dating, among the oldest Acheulian occurrences outside Africa.

- Acheulian tools were recovered from a 4 m thick clay deposit; the artefacts, mostly bifacial handaxes and cleavers, were made of quartzite not available locally, and the near-absence of debitage shows they were manufactured elsewhere and carried to the site. A quartz tool of non-local origin was also recovered.
- A set of animal footprints was found along with Acheulian tools: 17 round impressions of 15-20 cm together with a set of hoofprints, the first discovery of its kind in South Asia.
- Three fossil teeth, probably of a horse, water buffalo and nilgai, indicate an open and wet landscape in early Palaeolithic times.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Bagalkot

Karnataka



LOCATION Bagalkot district, northern Karnataka, in the Malaprabha-Ghataprabha basin of the Krishna system.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower to Middle Palaeolithic, part of the stratified Lower-to-Upper Palaeolithic sequence identified in the Malaprabha-Ghataprabha valleys.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE An early-to-middle Palaeolithic tool zone dominated by Acheulian handaxes and cleavers, with pebble tools such as choppers and chopping tools occurring alongside them.

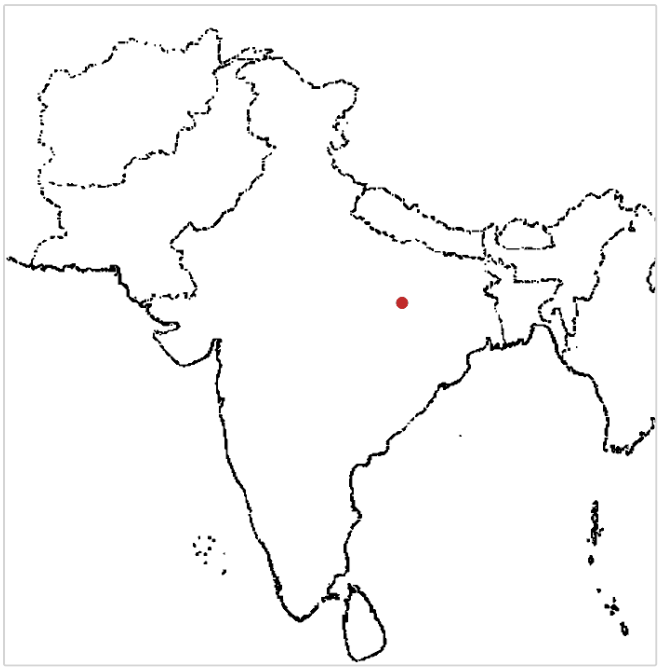
- Kavalli nearby is an open-air factory site, where tools survive in successive stages of preparation close to the raw material source.
- The co-occurrence of pebble tools with handaxes here helped overturn the older view that the southern Lower Palaeolithic, then called "Madrasian", was distinct from the pebble-tool traditions of the north-west.
- The same district later became the heartland of Chalukyan temple architecture at Badami, Aihole and Pattadakal on the Malaprabha.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Baghor MP

Madhya Pradesh

ALSO: MESOLITHIC



LOCATION Baghor I, II and III, Sidhi district, Madhya Pradesh, in the Son valley on the fringe of the Kaimur hills.

PERIOD/LEVEL Upper Palaeolithic, the shrine dated to about 9000-8000 BCE; excavated jointly by G. R. Sharma of Allahabad University and J. D. Clark of the University of California, Berkeley.

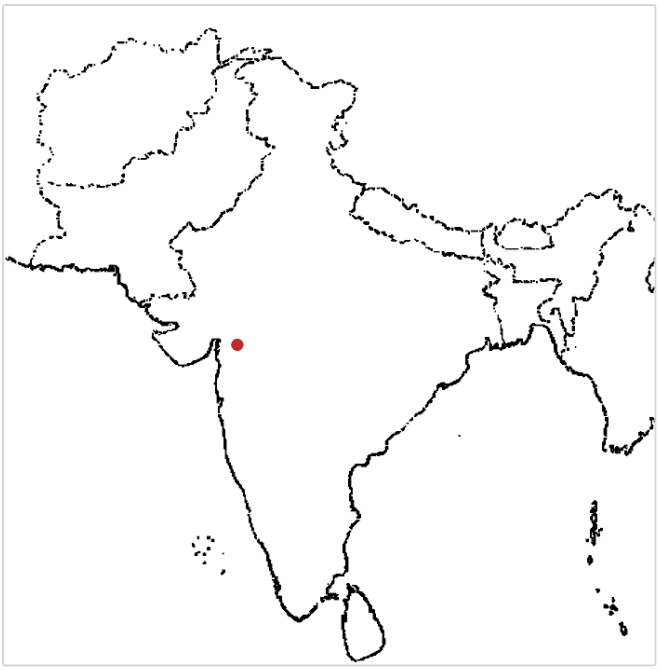
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Baghor I has yielded the clearest evidence of an Upper Palaeolithic shrine anywhere in the subcontinent, and so of organised religious activity among hunter-gatherers.

- A roughly circular platform of sandstone rubble about 85 cm across carried at its centre a natural stone with concentric triangular laminations ranging from light yellowish red to dark reddish brown; nine further fragments found on or near the platform join into a triangle about 15 cm high.
- The Kol and Baiga people who live in the Kaimur hills today build similar circular rubble platforms and worship such triangular stones as a symbol of the female principle, an ethnographic parallel of unusual directness.
- A microwear study of Baghor III (Sinha, 1989) identified boring, scraping and whittling associated with craft work, and cutting, slicing, piercing and chopping linked to food processing and hunting, with polish on some tools showing they had been hafted onto handles.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Bhandarpur

Gujarat



LOCATION Bhandarpur, in the lower Narmada basin of eastern Gujarat, in the tract where the Orsang and Karjan join the main river.

PERIOD/LEVEL Middle to Upper Palaeolithic, with a microblade horizon.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The microblade assemblage recovered here belongs to the class of evidence used to trace the dispersal of anatomically modern humans out of Africa into South Asia.

- Microblade industries of this kind, dated across western and central India, are central to the debate on when fully modern human populations entered the subcontinent and how that relates to the Toba super-eruption of about 75,000 years ago.
- Gujarat's Lower Palaeolithic is otherwise known from the valleys of the Sabarmati and its Orsang and Karjan tributaries, and from the Bhadar valley in Saurashtra, so Bhandarpur extends that record into the later Palaeolithic.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (the Gujarat valleys and the Toba eruption; the Bhandarpur microblade finds are from the author's notes)*

Bhimbetka

Madhya Pradesh

ALSO: MESOLITHIC, ROCKCUT CAVES, PETROGLYPH SITES(CAVE PAINTING)



LOCATION Bhimbetka, Raisen district, Madhya Pradesh, about 45 km south of Bhopal and 30 km north of Hoshangabad, on a sandstone and quartzite hillside of the Vindhyas overlooking the Narmada; brought to notice and excalvated by V. S. Wakankar, and inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2003.

PERIOD/LEVEL An exceptionally long sequence running from the Lower Palaeolithic through the Mesolithic to the historic period, across hundreds of rock shelters.

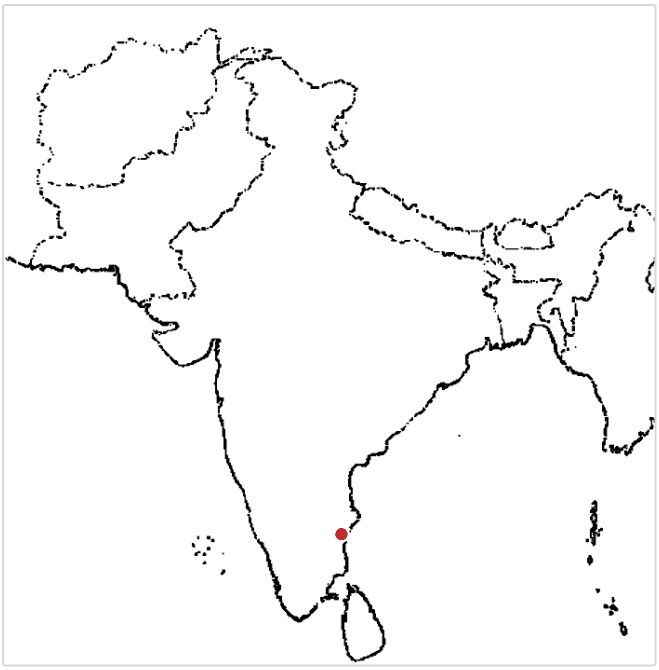
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The single most important prehistoric site in India, combining the longest occupation sequence with the richest body of rock art.

- Most tools were made of a yellowish quartzite available locally, with a grey quartzite obtained from further away; five floors paved with flat stone slabs belong to the Lower Palaeolithic. No bones have been found, probably because of the acidic soil.
- Cave III F-24, the "Auditorium Cave", stands on the borderline of the Lower and Middle Palaeolithic. A large rock in the middle of the hall carries seven cupules up to 16.8 mm deep, and a second rock has a single large cup mark with a meandering line; these were most likely made deliberately as part of a community ritual.
- A chalcedony disc was found in an Acheulian context, and ostrich eggshell beads about 6 mm across came from an Upper Palaeolithic burial, lying at the neck of the skull of a buried man.
- The Mesolithic paintings, executed in green and dark red, show hunters in red and dancers in green, along with large animal figures of bison, elephant, tiger and rhinoceros and geometric patterns; the shelters were attractive because of three perennial springs, about 30 plant types yielding edible fruits, tubers and roots, and abundant game.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; R. S Sharma, India's Ancient Past*

Chittoor

Andhra Pradesh



LOCATION Chittoor district, southern Andhra Pradesh, around Renigunta in the Velikonda and Nagari hills of the Eastern Ghats.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic, with continuity of occupation into the Megalithic period.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The area shows an unusually complete cultural sequence from the Palaeolithic to the Megalithic, making it a standard reference for long-term continuity in the southern Eastern Ghats.

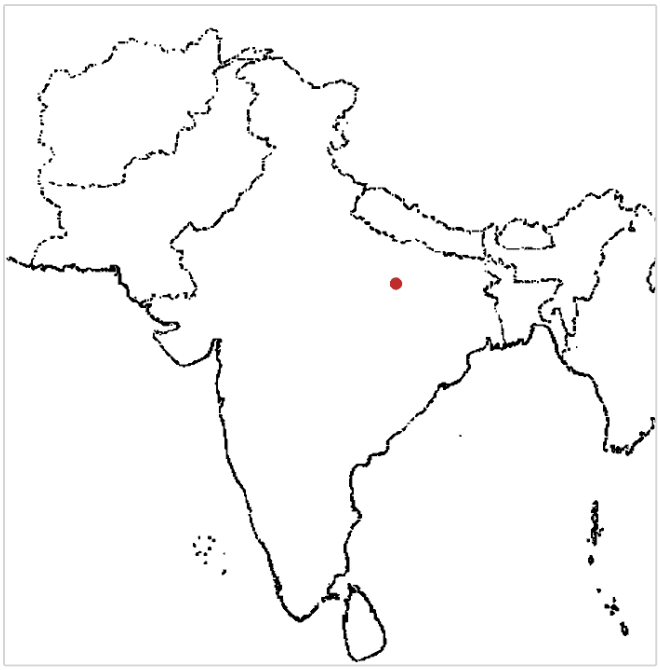
- Acheulian tools occur together with Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic material; two sites have been identified, one of them clearly dominant.
- Finds include handaxes and pebble tools of varying sizes; the large number of tools and the distinctive flaking suggest a source of raw material close at hand.
- Upper Palaeolithic artefacts were recovered from a cave at Renigunta, one of a series of such finds along the east coast of peninsular India dated between about 25,000 and 10,000 years ago.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Chopani Mando

Uttar Pradesh

ALSO: MESOLITHIC



LOCATION Chopani Mando, in the Belan valley on the Vindhyan fringe of the Allahabad (Prayagraj) and Mirzapur tract, Uttar Pradesh; excavated by G. R. Sharma of Allahabad University.

PERIOD/LEVEL A habitation site with a cultural sequence running from the Upper Palaeolithic (Period I) through the Mesolithic (Periods II and III, with geometric microliths in Period IIB) to the Neolithic; the Belan Upper Palaeolithic is dated between 25,000 and 19,000 years ago.

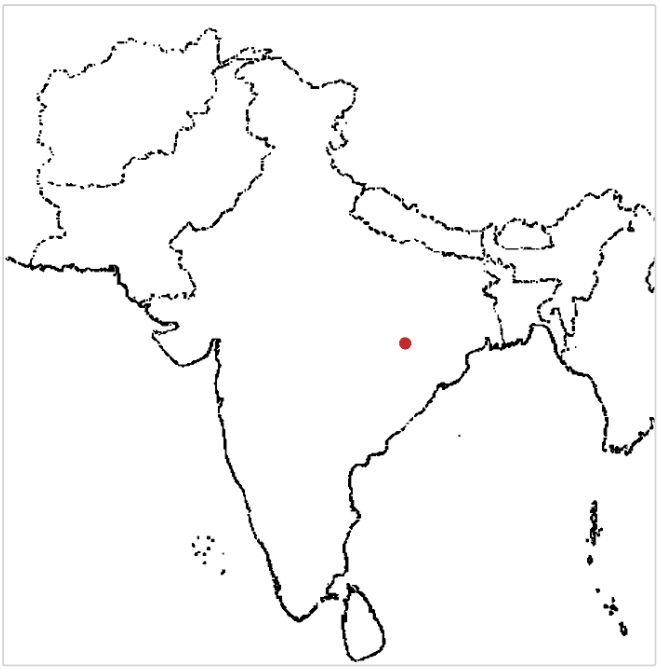
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The classic Indian site for the transition from hunting and gathering to settled food production, set within a valley whose sequence runs unbroken from the Lower Palaeolithic to the Neolithic.

- The Palaeolithic levels yielded tools of chert, a stone available in the nearby Vindhyas.
- Period III produced handmade pottery with cord-impressed patterns, among the earliest pottery known in India, along with querns and mullers for processing wild grains.
- Wild rice was recovered, though whether it was domesticated remains debated; the huts were beehive-shaped in the earlier phase and oval, clustered and wattle-and-daub later, evidenced by burnt clay bearing reed impressions.
- Bones of sheep and goat, animals not indigenous to the area, suggest either contact with the north-west or an early stage of animal domestication.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Dari Dungari

Odisha



LOCATION Dari-dungri, Sambalpur district, Odisha, in the Mahanadi basin.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower and Middle Palaeolithic.

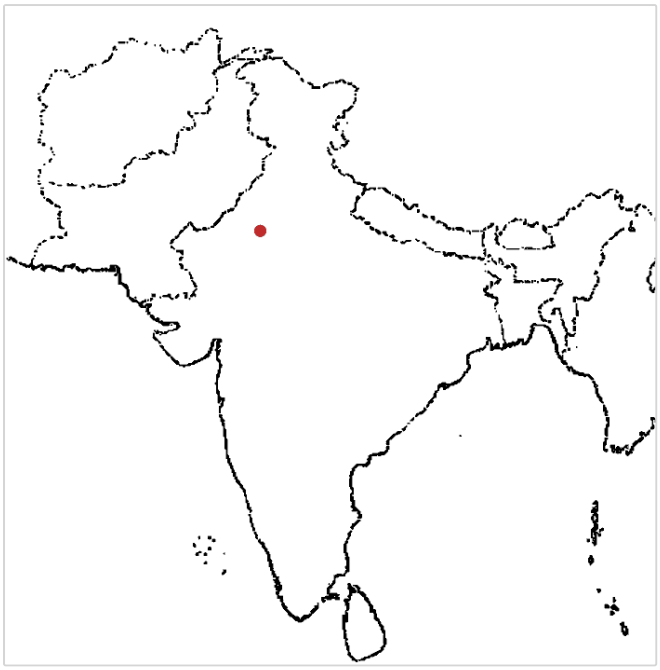
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Explorations here recovered a large number of Lower and Middle Palaeolithic tools, making it one of the richest surface concentrations in the Mahanadi system.

- Tools of all three phases of the Palaeolithic have been found at many places in Odisha, and Lower Palaeolithic material also occurs along the valleys of the Budhabalanga and Brahmani rivers.
- Together with the river valleys and foothills of the Chhotanagpur plateau, these finds establish continuous Palaeolithic occupation across the eastern Indian uplands.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2*

Didwana or Nagaur

Rajasthan



LOCATION Didwana, Nagaur district, western Rajasthan, on the eastern margin of the Thar desert beside the Didwana salt lake; the principal localities are Singi Talav and Amarpura. Studied in detail by V. N. Misra and S. N. Rajaguru.

PERIOD/LEVEL A stratigraphic profile extending from the early to the middle Palaeolithic. The Lower Palaeolithic is dated 390,000 BP by the uranium-thorium series method, and the Middle Palaeolithic has two thermoluminescence dates of 150,000 BP and 144,000 BP.

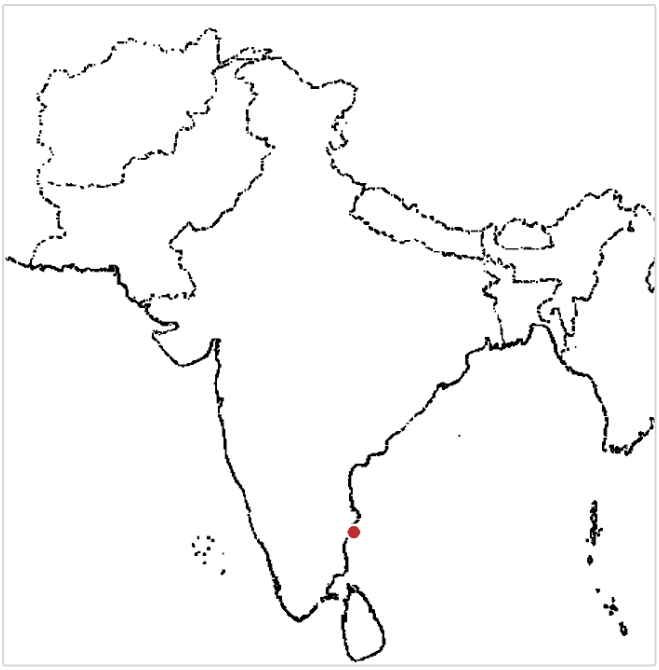
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the very few Indian sites with absolute dates for both the Lower and Middle Palaeolithic, and the anchor for reconstructing the palaeo-environment of the Thar.

- Finds include handaxes, cleavers and choppers in stratified deposits.
- The study shows that the present environment of the Thar is very different from that of the Pleistocene: except for a phase in the upper Pleistocene between 25,000 and 13,000 BP, surface water was always available in some quantity and the flora and fauna were far more abundant than today.
- Sediments of the salt lakes record a significant increase in rainfall in the mid-Holocene, about 6000-4000 BP, precisely the period to which the most widespread prehistoric occupation of the area belongs.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; Satish Chandra, Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I; R. S Sharma, India's Ancient Past*

Gudiyam Caves

Tamil Nadu



LOCATION Gudiyam cave, in the hills of the Kortallayar basin, Tiruvallur district, not far from Chennai, Tamil Nadu.

PERIOD/LEVEL A sequence of Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic tools.

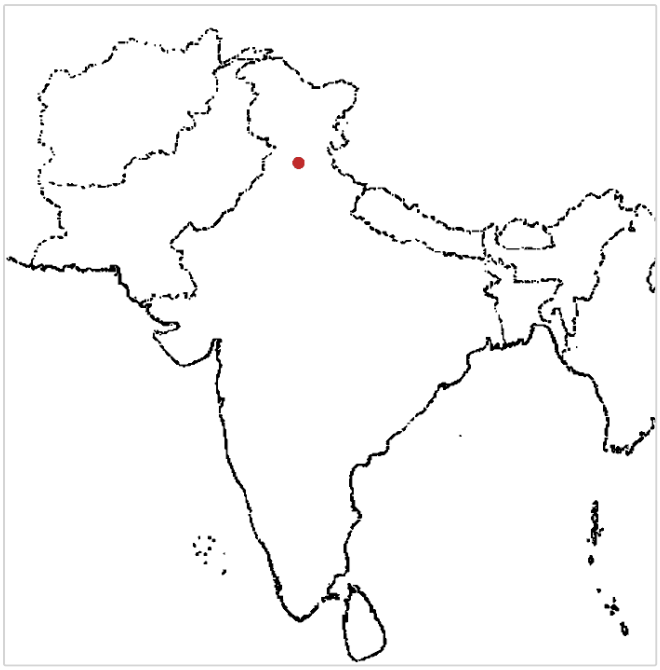
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The cave has yielded a complete Lower-to-Upper Palaeolithic tool sequence, one of the few cave stratigraphies available in South India.

- The small number of tools and the absence of other remains suggest that the site was occupied only for short periods at a time, a transit or seasonal shelter rather than a base camp.
- With Attirampakkam and Pallavaram nearby, Gudiyam makes the Kortallayar basin the classic stratified Palaeolithic region of Tamil Nadu, giving a sequence from the early Palaeolithic to the Mesolithic near Chennai.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Gumarwin

Himachal Pradesh



LOCATION Ghumarwin, Bilaspur district, Himachal Pradesh, in the Siwalik foothills of the Sutlej basin.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic, with Acheulian and Soanian material occurring together.

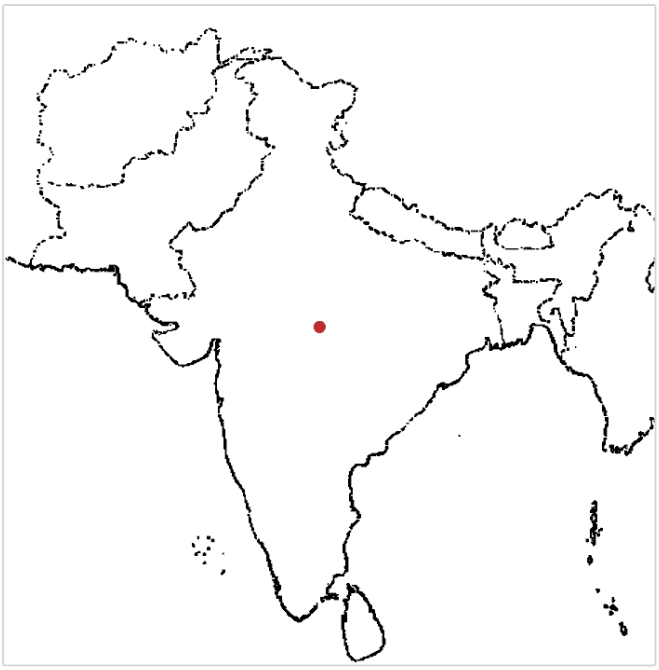
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The association of Acheulian and Soanian tools at one locality argues against treating the two as separate and mutually exclusive cultures, and points instead to continuity between them.

- Finds include bifacial handaxes, cleavers, scrapers and Acheulian choppers.
- Fossil remains of Sivapithecus, one of the "God-Apes of the Siwaliks" and an ancestor of the orangutan, have been recovered here; such Siwalik apes, including Ramapithecus and Brahmapithecus, were dated between 10 and 14 million years ago.
- Vertebrate and invertebrate fossils together with the fossilised tuber of a tree allow the ecology of the period to be reconstructed.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (the Siwalik fossil apes; the Ghumarwin finds are from the author's notes)*

Hathnora

Madhya Pradesh



LOCATION Hathnora village, on the northern bank of the Narmada about 40 km north-east of Hoshangabad, Sehore district, Madhya Pradesh.

PERIOD/LEVEL Middle Pleistocene, in a late Acheulian to Middle Palaeolithic context; estimated dates for the hominid finds range between 0.5 and 0.2 million years ago.

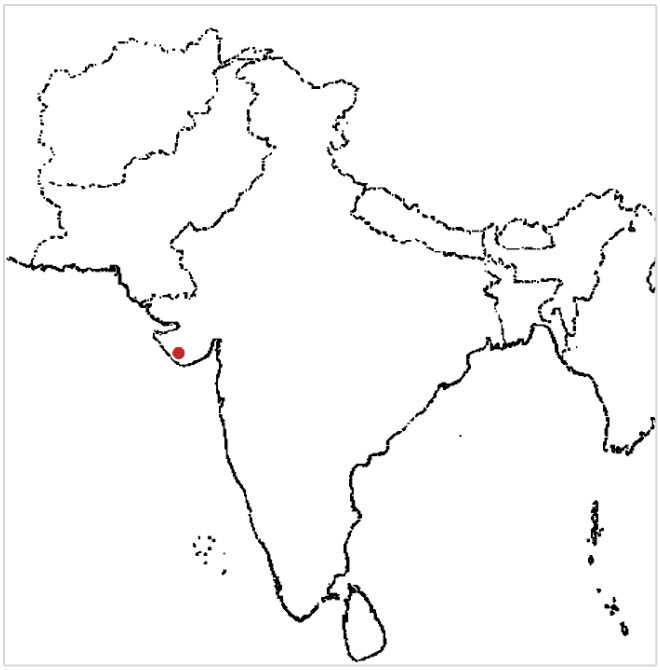
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The only well-authenticated Pleistocene hominid fossil locality in India, which places the subcontinent within the global story of human evolution.

- In 1982 Arun Sonakia of the Geological Survey of India found a fossilised cranial fragment embedded in thick, closely packed sandy, pebbly gravel, along with fossils of proboscideans and bovids and a few late Acheulian tools.
- The skull fragment belonged to a woman of about 30. Sonakia named her Homo erectus narmadensis, treating her as an advanced variety of Homo erectus because of the larger cranial capacity range of 1155 to 1421 cc; other scholars regard the cranium as that of an early or archaic Homo sapiens, and its date remains disputed.
- In 1997 A. R. Sankhyan reported a hominid clavicle from the same boulder conglomerate deposit, together with animal fossils and several middle or late Palaeolithic tools, following the Anthropological Survey of India's intensive search of the central Narmada valley between 1983 and 1992.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; R. S Sharma, India's Ancient Past*

Hiran Valley

Gujarat



LOCATION The Hiran river valley in Saurashtra, Gujarat, draining the southern flank of the Gir hills.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic dated between 190,000 and 69,000 BP, and Middle Palaeolithic dated 56,800 BP, both by the uranium-thorium series method.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the very few sequences in Gujarat to carry absolute dates for both the Lower and the Middle Palaeolithic, giving Saurashtra a securely fixed Pleistocene framework.

- The dates place the Hiran valley alongside Didwana in Rajasthan, the Son valley in Madhya Pradesh and Nevasa in Maharashtra as the small group of Indian localities where Lower Palaeolithic contexts have been dated absolutely rather than by typology alone.
- Lower Palaeolithic tools elsewhere in Gujarat come from the Sabarmati and its Orsang and Karjan tributaries and from the Bhadar valley, so the Hiran dates supply the chronology for that wider regional record.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Hunasgi

Karnataka



LOCATION The Hunsgi valley, Gulbarga (Kalaburagi) district, Karnataka, on the banks of the Hunsgi, a tributary of the Krishna; investigated by K. Paddayya from 1982 onwards.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic (Acheulian), with Middle Palaeolithic occupation at the associated site of Isampur, where prehistoric occupation goes back to between 500,000 and 600,000 years ago.

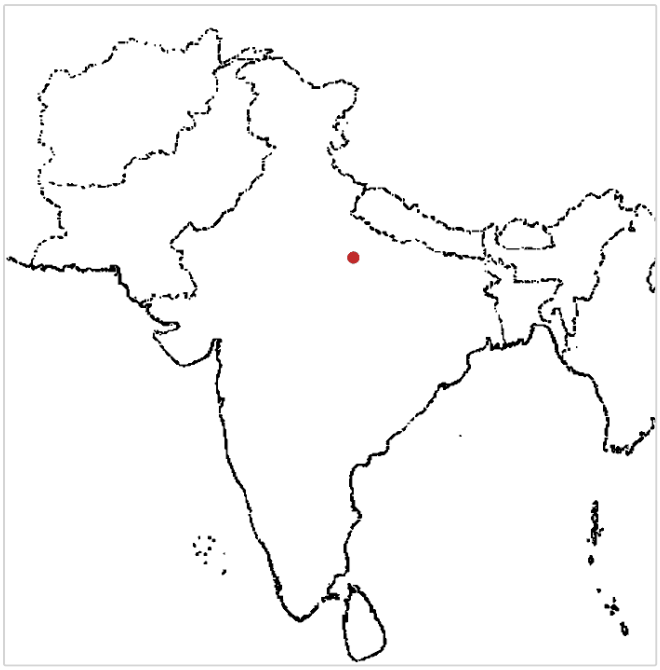
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The classic Indian demonstration of Acheulian settlement patterns, where the size and composition of sites have been used to reconstruct how hunter-gatherer bands used a landscape.

- Sites with very few artefact types represent places where specific activities such as tool-making or killing game were carried out; sites with tools in larger number and variety were probably temporary camps; the largest sites, with tools in great profusion, were places where groups lived for longer periods.
- The tools were made of limestone, sandstone, quartzite, dolerite and chert, some of which were not locally available; in one excavated area huge granite blocks were arranged around a 63 sq m space, probably to support temporary shelters of branches, grass and leaves.
- At Isampur, covering about 7,200 sq m, siliceous limestone slabs were quarried and worked: the Acheulian material consists mainly of cores, large flakes and debitage, with chopping tools, knives, handaxes, cleavers and scrapers, and hammer stones of quartzite, basalt and chert in very large numbers. Unfinished tools far outnumber finished ones, marking it as a centre of stone tool manufacture and also a habitation site.
- The area today supports about 40 types of wild edible plants and plenty of small game, which helps explain the density of occupation.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Kalpi

Uttar Pradesh



LOCATION Kalpi, Jalaun district, Uttar Pradesh, on the southern bank of the Yamuna, where the finds lie embedded in a 20 m thick cliff section.

PERIOD/LEVEL Middle Palaeolithic; the tool-bearing level has been dated to about 45,000 years ago.

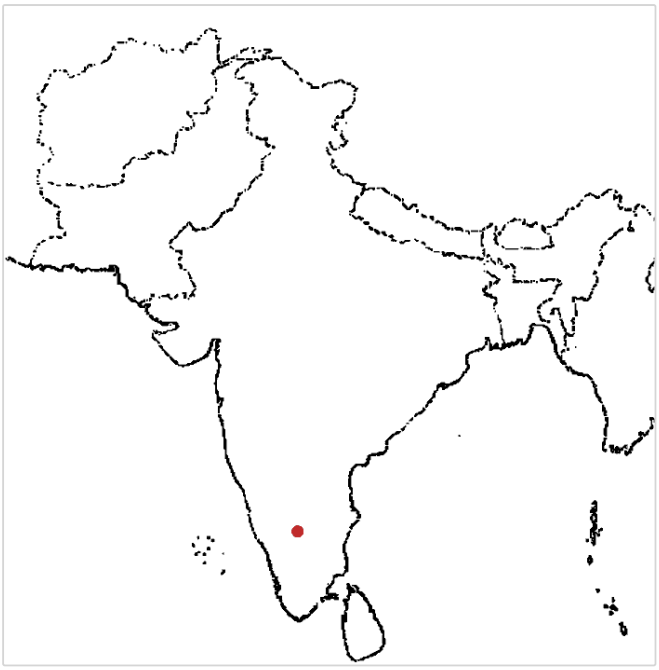
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Kalpi preserves the earliest trace of human occupation in the Ganga plain, a region where deep alluvium normally conceals or destroys Palaeolithic evidence.

- Vertebrate fossils recovered here include an elephant tusk and shoulder blade and the molars of Equus and bovids.
- The stone tools include pebble tools, points and side scrapers, and were found together with bone tools such as end scrapers, points and burins, an uncommon association in the Indian Middle Palaeolithic.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; J. L Mehta, Advanced Study in the History of Medieval India, Vol. I*

Kibbanahalli

Karnataka



LOCATION Kibbanahalli, Tumkur district, southern Karnataka, in the upper Cauvery drainage.

PERIOD/LEVEL Middle Palaeolithic, with a later microlithic or Mesolithic presence at the same locality.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the type localities for the Middle Palaeolithic flake industries of southern Karnataka.

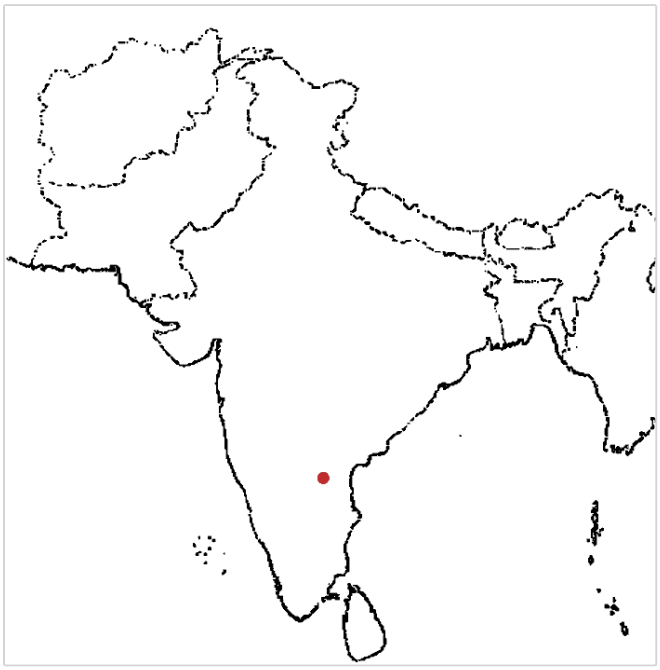
- Finds include handaxes and guillotine chisels.
- Mesolithic tools of quartz have also been recovered, showing that the locality continued to be used into the microlithic phase.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (the quartz microliths; the Middle Palaeolithic finds are from the author's notes)*

Kurnool

Andhra Pradesh

ALSO: MESOLITHIC



LOCATION The Kurnool cave complex, including Muchchatla Chintamanu Gavi and the Billa Surgam caves, Kurnool district, Andhra Pradesh, in the limestone hills of the Nallamalai range.

PERIOD/LEVEL Upper Palaeolithic, with two electron spin resonance dates of 19,224 BP and 16,686 BP.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Kurnool and Muchchatla Chintamanu Gavi are the only places in the subcontinent where tools made of animal bone have been found in an Upper Palaeolithic context; in one of the caves as many as 90 per cent of the excavated tools were of bone.

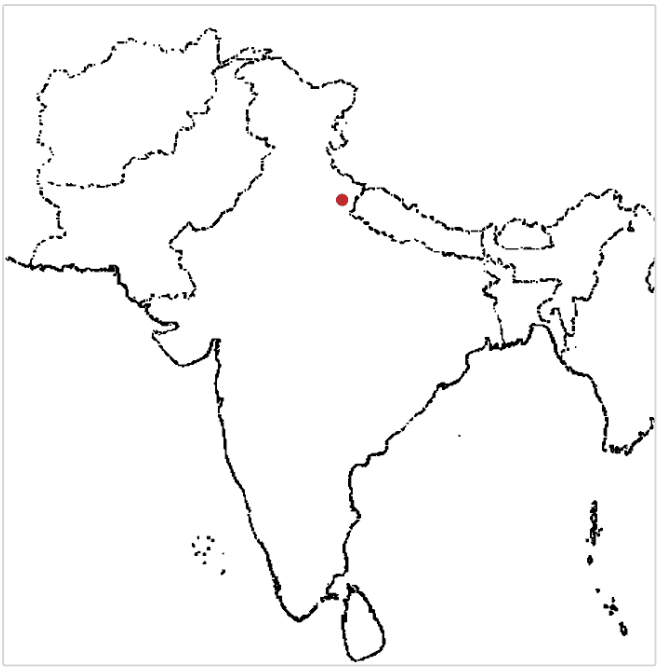
- Animal teeth found in one cave have grooves suggesting they were strung and worn as ornaments; ash deposits show familiarity with fire, and painted rock shelters occur alongside the naturally formed caves.
- The faunal list is exceptionally long, including bat, nilgai, four-horned antelope, gazelle, chital, sambar, barking deer, mouse deer, wild boar, tiger, leopard, jungle cat, spotted hyena, civet, freshwater fish, mongoose, sloth bear, porcupine, hare, grey langur, horse, ass, rhinoceros and giant pangolin.
- Besides recording the animals that Upper Palaeolithic people shared their landscape with, this range indicates that thick forests and far more humid conditions prevailed in the area than today.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; Romila Thapar, Early India: From the Origins to AD 1300*

Lakhudiyar

Uttarakhand

ALSO: ROCKCUT CAVES, PETROGLYPH SITES(CAVE PAINTING)



LOCATION Lakhudiyar, on the bank of the Suyal river about 20 km from Almora on the Almora-Barechhina road, Uttarakhand - a rock shelter in the Kumaon hills. The name means "a hundred thousand caves".

PERIOD/LEVEL Rock paintings assigned broadly to the Mesolithic and later prehistoric periods, with some figures argued to be Chalcolithic. The shelter carries superimposed layers in three colours, the black generally earlier, then red ochre, with white over both.

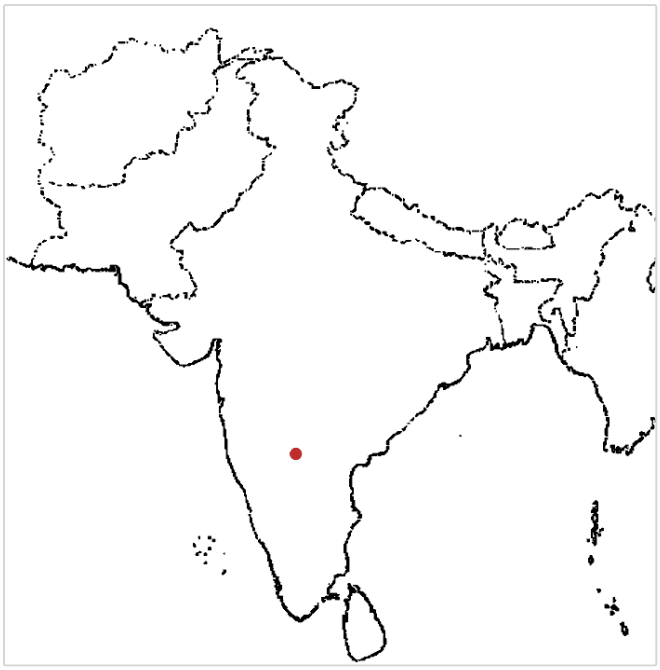
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The principal prehistoric rock art site of the central Himalaya - the northern counterpart to Bhimbetka.

- The paintings show stick-like human figures holding hands in rows, read as dancing or as a group ritual, along with animals - long-snouted quadrupeds, foxes, lizards - and geometric and wavy patterns.
- Human figures greatly outnumber animals, which is the opposite of the pattern at Bhimbetka and in the Vindhyan shelters. That difference is the site's analytical value: Indian rock art is usually discussed through the central Indian material, and Lakhudiyar shows a distinct regional tradition with its own subject preferences.
- The three-colour superimposition allows a relative sequence to be worked out even without absolute dates, which is how most Indian rock art is dated.
- Other Kumaon and Garhwal shelters - Falseema, Petshala, Kasar Devi - belong to the same group, so the region has a cluster rather than an isolated site, and it should be read with the Garhwal Neolithic settlement at Thapli.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2; R. S. Sharma, India's Ancient Past; ASI*

Lingsugur- Same as Maski 1st palae site to be discovered

Karnataka



LOCATION Lingsugur, Raichur district, Karnataka, in the Krishna-Tungabhadra doab, close to Maski.

PERIOD/LEVEL Palaeolithic surface finds, in a tract better known for its Neolithic ash-mound settlements.

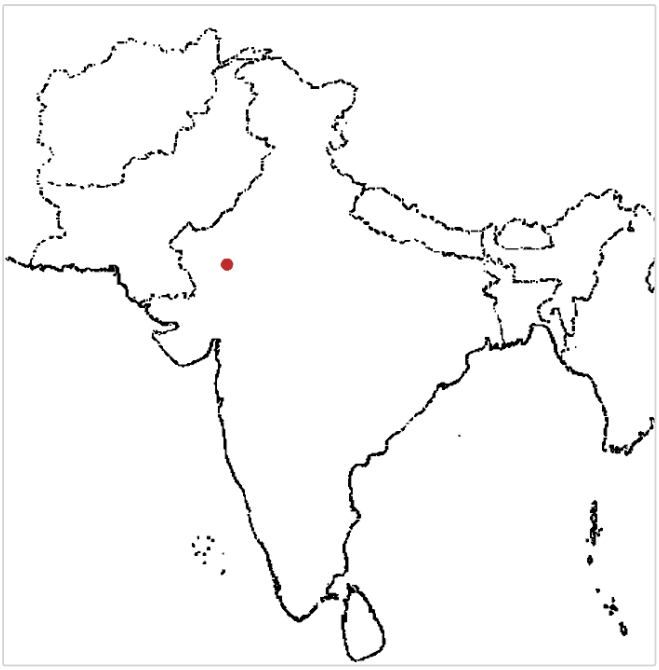
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE In 1842 Dr Primrose reported stone implements from Lingsugur, the earliest recorded discovery of a prehistoric stone tool in India, some two decades before Robert Bruce Foote picked up the Pallavaram handaxe in 1863.

- Primrose's find attracted no scholarly follow-up, which is why Foote's Pallavaram discovery is conventionally treated as the starting point of systematic Indian prehistory.
- The same tract, at Maski, later yielded the minor rock edict that is one of the very few Ashokan inscriptions to name the emperor as "Ashoka" rather than only by his titles, and the Raichur doab remained a contested frontier between Vijayanagara and the Bahmanis.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (Foote at Pallavaram, 1863) and ch. 7 (the Maski edict); Primrose's 1842 find at Lingsugur is reported in the secondary literature and not yet checked against a primary source*

Luni Valley

Rajasthan



LOCATION The Luni valley of western Rajasthan, draining the western flank of the Aravallis towards the Rann of Kutch, across the Nagaur and Jodhpur tract.

PERIOD/LEVEL Stray finds of Lower Palaeolithic tools, a well-represented Middle Palaeolithic, and a thinner Upper Palaeolithic.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The valley gives its name to the "Luni industry", the term used for Middle Palaeolithic assemblages west of the Aravallis, contrasted with the industry of the Berach and Chittorgarh region to the east.

- Middle Palaeolithic artefacts are markedly more abundant here than Upper Palaeolithic material.
- The decline in the number of Upper Palaeolithic sites reflects increasing aridity in the Thar during the late Pleistocene, when occupation contracted towards permanent water such as the Budha Pushkar lake.
- With Didwana and the Budha Pushkar basin, the Luni valley defines the Palaeolithic record of the Thar desert.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; A. L Basham, The Wonder That Was India*

Malprabha Ghatprabha valley

Karnataka



LOCATION The Malaprabha and Ghataprabha valleys, tributaries of the Krishna in the Belagavi and Bagalkot districts of northern Karnataka.

PERIOD/LEVEL A stratigraphic sequence of Lower and Upper Palaeolithic tools has been identified in these valleys.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the few stratified rather than surface Palaeolithic sequences in the Deccan, and the evidence that broke the old regional divide in Indian prehistory.

- Acheulian handaxes and cleavers occur together with pebble tools such as choppers and chopping tools.
- It was once believed that the Lower Palaeolithic industry of the south, then named "Madrasian", differed from that of the rest of the country because it supposedly lacked pebble tools. Research of the past few decades, here and in the Hunsgi-Baichbal and Krishna valleys, has shown this to be incorrect.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2*

Mandla

Madhya Pradesh



LOCATION Mandla district, eastern Madhya Pradesh, in the upper Narmada valley below Amarkantak.

PERIOD/LEVEL Palaeolithic surface finds, in a district whose exposures range back to the Mesozoic Gondwana and Lameta formations.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The locality illustrates the extraordinary geological depth of the upper Narmada, where prehistoric tools occur in a landscape of much older fossil beds.

- Fossilised plants have been found here along with mollusc fossils.
- Dinosaur egg fossils of the Mesozoic era have been reported from the district, part of the well-known dinosaur-bearing beds of the Narmada valley.
- Taken with Hathnora, Adamgarh and Bhimbetka downstream, Mandla completes the Narmada basin as the most intensively researched Palaeolithic region in central India.

SOURCES *Mandla Plant Fossils National Park, Madhya Pradesh (the plant and mollusc fossils); the Palaeolithic finds are from the author's notes*

Mandsaur

Madhya Pradesh

ALSO: NON ASHOKAN INSCRIPTION, FORTS



LOCATION Mandsaur district, western Madhya Pradesh, on the Chambal-Malwa plateau; the Palaeolithic evidence comes from the Daraki Chattan cave in the Indragarh hill.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic, the rock art dated to between 200,000 and 500,000 years ago; the site is also a major non-Ashokan inscription and fort site of the historic and medieval periods.

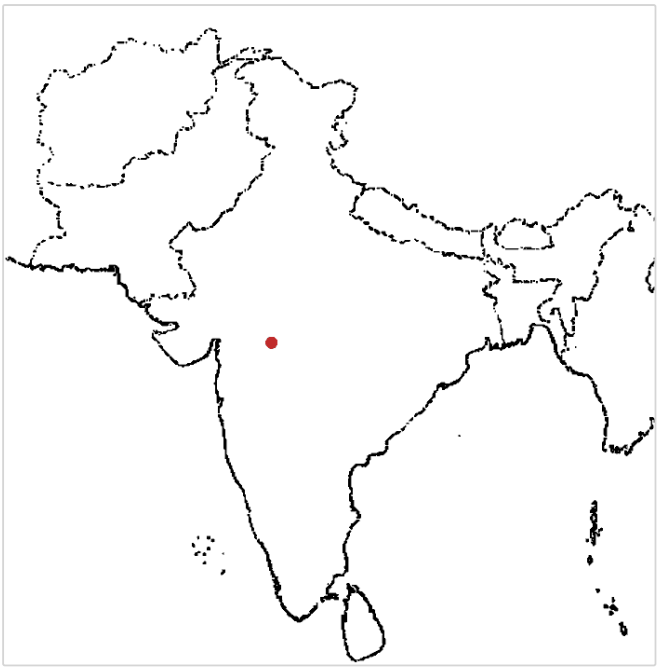
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE At Daraki Chattan more than five hundred pieces of rock art, cup-shaped depressions pecked into the quartzite, have been found together with hammer stones, making it among the oldest rock art sites in India and in the world.

- With the cupules of the Auditorium Cave at Bhimbetka, these petroglyphs push the origins of symbolic and ritual expression in India back into the Lower Palaeolithic.
- Mandsaur, ancient Dasapura, later carried the sixth-century Sanskrit inscription of Yasodharman marking his victory over the Huna king Mihirakula, and a fifth-century inscription of the time of Kumaragupta recording the migration of silk weavers from Lata to Dasapura, who organised themselves into a guild and built a sun temple.
- The fort was built by Hoshang Shah of the Malwa Sultanate, was occupied by Rana Sanga in 1519, and was the place where the treaty of 1818 bringing Malwa under British control was signed.

SOURCES *Romila Thapar, Early India: From the Origins to AD 1300*

Mehtakhedi

Madhya Pradesh



LOCATION Mehtakheri, Khargone district, Madhya Pradesh, in the middle Narmada valley.

PERIOD/LEVEL Upper Palaeolithic; a piece of ostrich eggshell from the site has been dated to over 41,900 BP, with artefacts in the range of about 50,000 years ago.

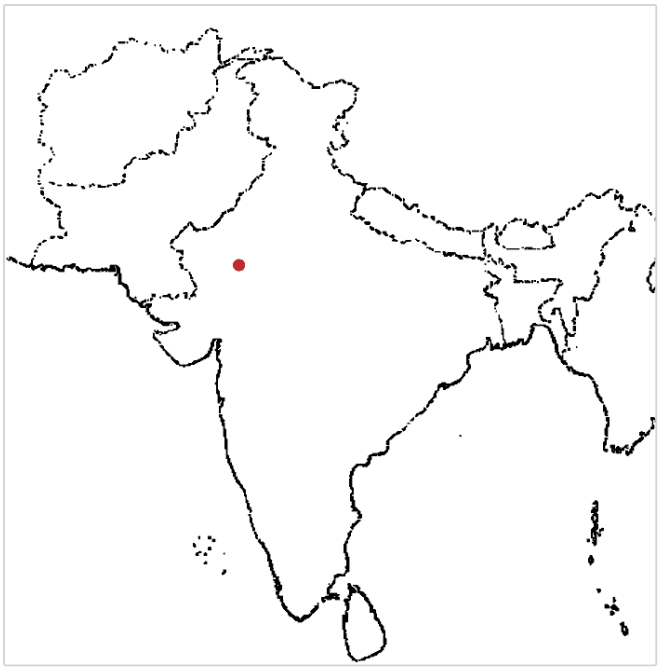
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Mehtakheri has produced one of the earliest dated microblade industries in India, and is therefore central to the debate on when microlithic technology, and with it anatomically modern humans, appeared in the subcontinent.

- The ostrich eggshell fragment is part of the wider Indian evidence that Struthio roamed many parts of Asia, including India, until the end of the Pleistocene or the early Holocene.
- About 50 such discoveries have been made across Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra, with dates from Chandresal in Rajasthan of 38,900 and 36,500 BP and from Ramnagar in Madhya Pradesh of over 31,000 BP.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Mogara Hills

Rajasthan



LOCATION Mogara hill near Jodhpur, western Rajasthan, on the eastern fringe of the Thar desert.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic, and Mesolithic.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The hill appears to have been a factory site where tools of all four phases were made, showing that the same raw material source was returned to across several hundred thousand years.

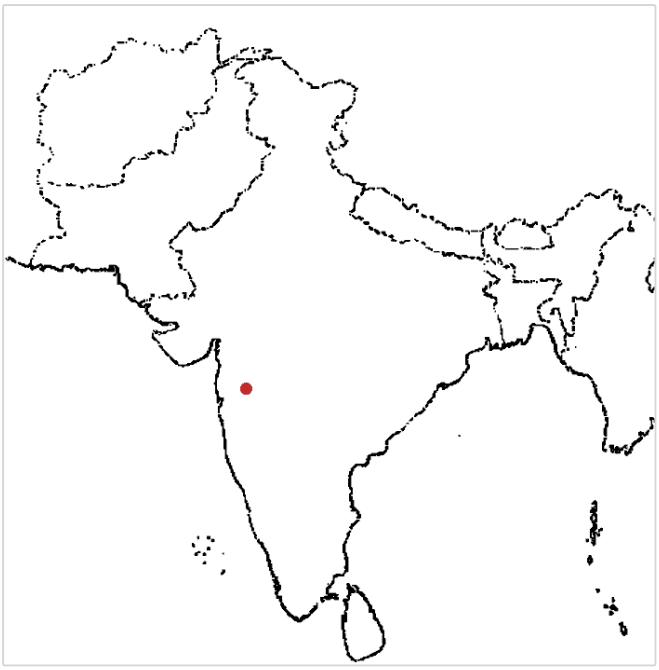
- Factory sites of this kind are generally located close to sources of raw material and are marked by a profusion of stone tools in various stages of preparation.
- Such long-lived quarry-workshops, like those in the Sukkur and Rohri hills of upper Sindh, indicate that knowledge of good stone sources was transmitted across an enormous span of prehistoric time.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Nashik

Maharashtra

ALSO: NON ASHOKAN INSCRIPTION



LOCATION Nashik, on the Godavari in northern Maharashtra; the Palaeolithic material comes from the Gangawadi area on the river bank.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic tools recovered in a stratigraphic context.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Nashik contributes one of the stratified river-section profiles on which H. D. Sankalia and his successors built the Palaeolithic sequence of the Deccan, alongside those of the Mula-Mutha, Pravara and Tapi.

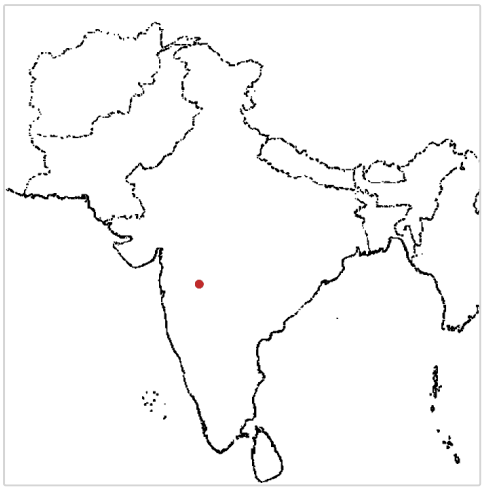
- Palaeolithic tools have been found in many places along the Maharashtra coast and in the Wardha-Wainganga valleys, with Lower and Middle Palaeolithic material in stratigraphic contexts in the Dattawadi area of the Mutha at Pune.
- In the historic period the Pandavleni caves above the town became a major Hinayana Buddhist centre: the Cave 10 inscription of Ushavadata, viceroy and son-in-law of the Western Kshatrapa ruler Nahapana, dated about 120 CE, is among the earliest known uses of Sanskrit in western India, and the Cave 3 inscription of Gautamiputra Satakarni, issued by his mother Gautami Balashri, records his military conquests and his feud with Nahapana.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Newasa

Maharashtra

ALSO: CHALCOLITHIC



LOCATION Nevasa, Ahmednagar district, Maharashtra, on the Pravara river, a tributary of the Godavari; the associated living and factory site of Chirki lies close by. Excavated by H. D. Sankalia of Deccan College.

PERIOD/LEVEL One mound with two widely separated occupations. The deeper levels carry a stratified Middle Palaeolithic industry, with a uranium-thorium date of about 350,000 BP; above them lies a Jorwe culture Chalcolithic settlement of roughly 1400-700 BCE.

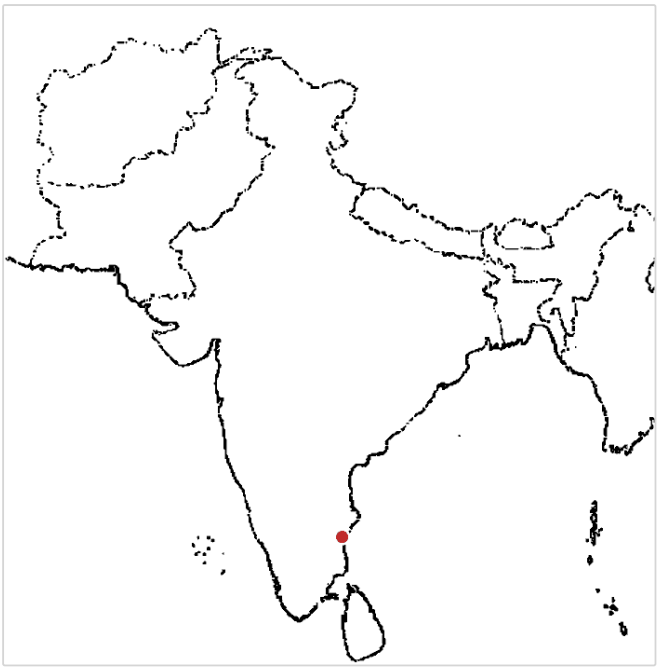
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The type site of the Indian Middle Palaeolithic, and one of the principal sources for Chalcolithic burial and belief in the Deccan.

- Sankalia found Middle Palaeolithic artefacts here in a stratified context for the first time, and the "Nevasan" is accordingly the name given to the Middle Palaeolithic of central and peninsular India. The industry is flake-based, dominated by scrapers of every kind - convex, concave, side, end and angle - with points and borers.
- The tools are worked in fine-grained agate, jasper and chalcedony rather than the coarse quartzite of the Lower Palaeolithic, and that shift in raw material is the diagnostic marker of the Middle Palaeolithic in India. Chirki nearby yielded some two thousand tools from a living and factory site.
- In the Chalcolithic levels, children were buried in twin urns set mouth to mouth beneath house floors - the characteristic Jorwe practice of keeping the dead within the home rather than in a separate cemetery.
- Some child burials at Nevasa and Chandoli carry copper necklaces while others have only pots, a difference read as emerging social inequality. Baked and unbaked female figurines point to a fertility or mother-goddess cult, the unbaked ones apparently made for a single ritual use.
- Cotton and semal silk threads from the site show cloth manufacture in Chalcolithic Maharashtra.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 and 5; R. S. Sharma, India's Ancient Past; H. D. Sankalia, Prehistory and Protohistory of India and Pakistan*

Odai

Tamil Nadu



LOCATION Odai, Villupuram district, Tamil Nadu, near Tiruvakkarai in the South Pennar tract.

PERIOD/LEVEL Middle to Upper Palaeolithic with microliths; the hominid remains belong to the middle to upper Pleistocene.

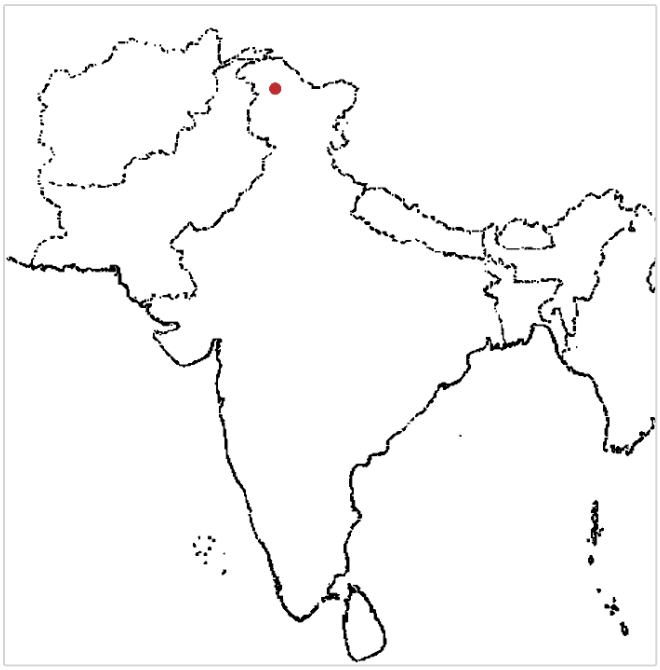
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the very few hominid fossil localities in the subcontinent, marked alongside Hathnora on standard maps of hominid discoveries in South Asia.

- A skull cap of the middle to upper Pleistocene was recovered here, and a complete fossilised human infant skull was found in association with microliths, dated to about 166,000 years ago.
- Petrified wood fossils roughly 20 million years old also occur; the trees are thought to have been transported to the spot before being petrified.
- With Tiruvakkarai nearby, Odai makes this stretch of northern Tamil Nadu one of the richest prehistoric and palaeontological landscapes in the state.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Pahalgam

Jammu and Kashmir



LOCATION Pahalgam, in the Liddar valley of Anantnag district, Kashmir.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic, represented by a handaxe find.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The handaxe recovered here is one of a very small number of Palaeolithic finds from Kashmir, where cold conditions, glacial action and thick karewa sedimentation mean that tools are rarely found or preserved.

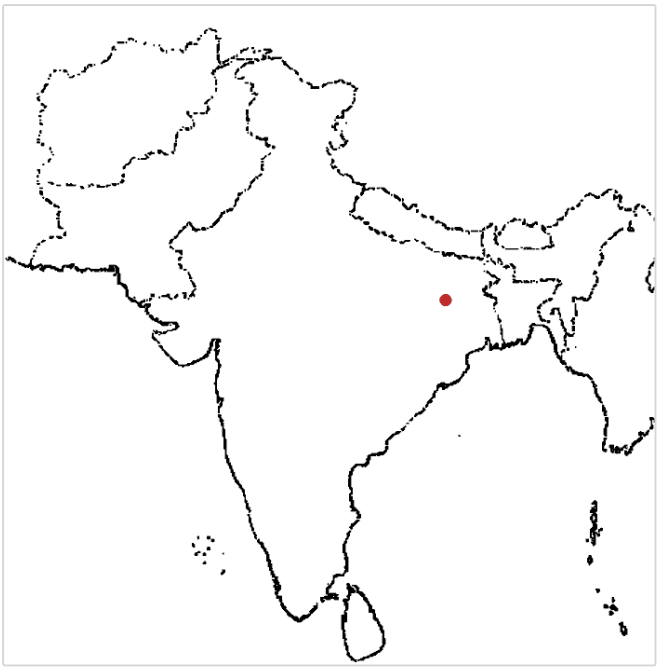
- The Kashmir Upper Palaeolithic has been dated to about 18,000 BP and coincides with the onset of a milder climate.
- De Terra and Paterson's attempt in 1935 to correlate the Soan river terraces with a four-fold Kashmir glacial cycle, and further with a four-fold European cycle, is no longer accepted, though it marked an important stage in the history of prehistoric research in India.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (the Kashmir Upper Palaeolithic and the de Terra-Paterson study; the Pahalgam handaxe is from the author's notes)*

Paisra

Bihar

ALSO: MESOLITHIC



LOCATION Paisra, in the Kharagpur forests near Munger, Bihar, on the northern fringe of the Chhotanagpur plateau; excavated by Pant and Jayaswal (1991).

PERIOD/LEVEL A Lower Palaeolithic living and working floor, with Upper Palaeolithic material also present in the wider Munger and Rajmahal (Damin) region.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE One of the rare Lower Palaeolithic sites in India to yield structural evidence of dwellings, showing that Acheulian groups built shelters in the open and did not depend only on caves and rock shelters.

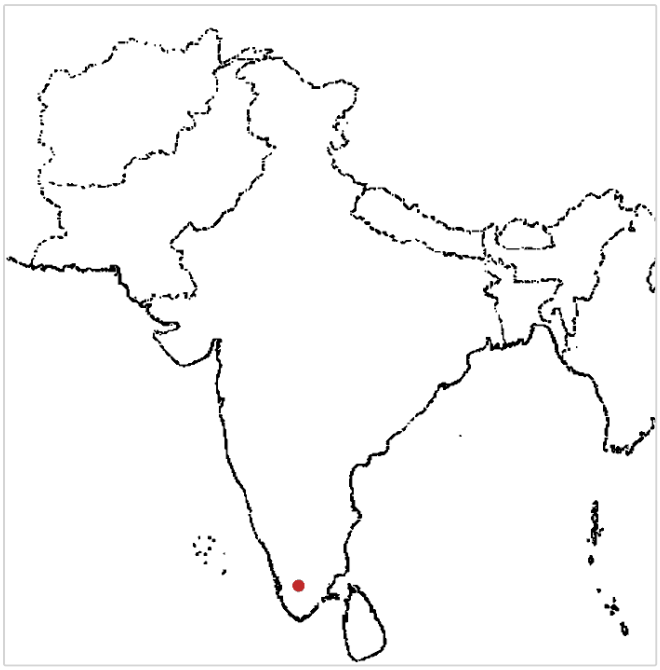
- Eight post-holes were found, marking places where wooden posts had been dug into the ground to support thatched huts.
- The whole area was rich in finished and unfinished artefacts, broken pieces of stone and anvils, marking it as a stone working site as well as a habitation.
- Large and small fireplaces occur close together, indicating organised use of space within the settlement.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Palakkad

Kerala

ALSO: FORTS



LOCATION Palakkad (Palghat) district, Kerala, at the Palghat gap, the major natural break in the Western Ghats linking the Tamil plains with the Kerala coast.

PERIOD/LEVEL Palaeolithic surface finds.

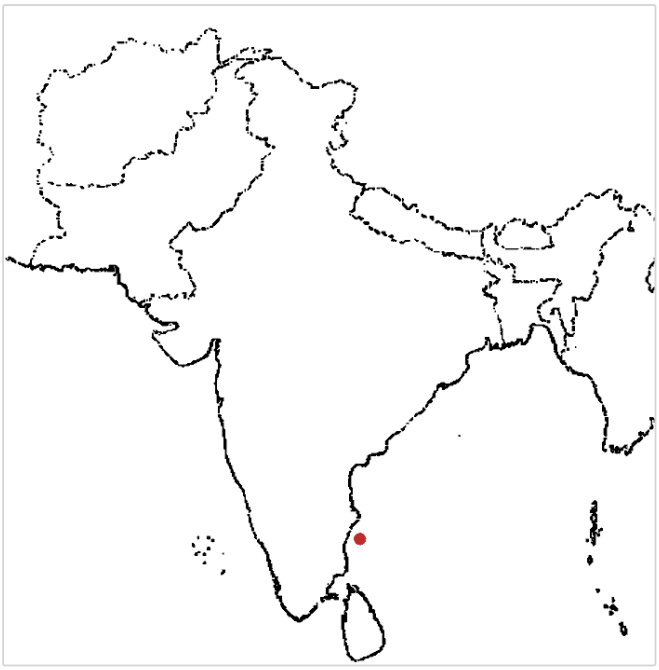
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Choppers and scrapers made of quartz have been found in the district, among the few Palaeolithic finds reported from Kerala, where heavy rainfall and thick laterite cover make prehistoric sites scarce and hard to locate.

- The Palghat gap itself explains the importance of the district, since it is the corridor through which people, and later trade and armies, moved between the Coromandel and Malabar coasts.
- The fort at Palakkad, in its present form the work of Hyder Ali, later served as a base for operations directed at Srirangapatna.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2; Thapar, Early India, on the Palghat Gap route (the fort is from the author's notes)*

Pallavaram

Tamil Nadu



LOCATION Pallavaram, near Chennai, formerly Madras, Tamil Nadu.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic (Acheulian).

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE In the summer of 1863 Robert Bruce Foote, an officer of the Geological Survey of India on routine survey duty, noticed a stone embedded in a gravel pit here: a seemingly unremarkable piece of brownish quartzite with one end chipped off, which he recognised as a handaxe. It was the first Palaeolithic tool discovered in India.

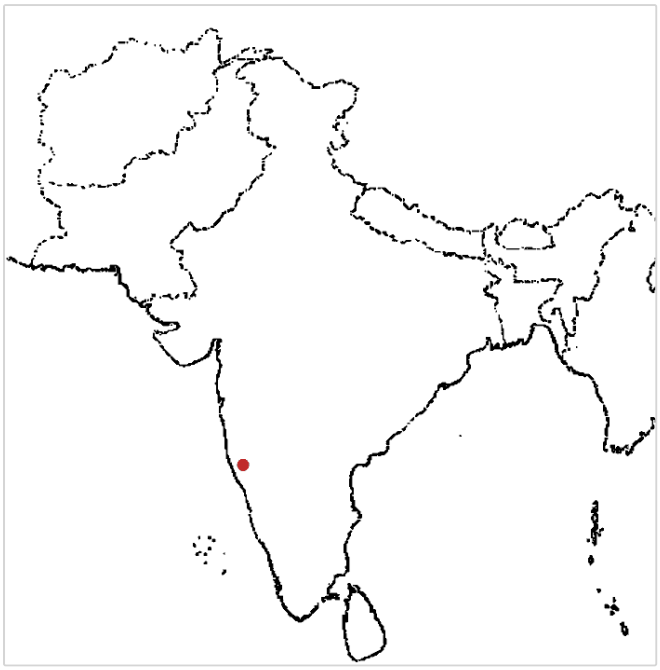
- Foote went on to find and study many more stone tools and made major contributions to research on Indian prehistory, earning the title "Father of Indian Prehistory".
- The Pallavaram handaxe was not strictly the first prehistoric tool found in India; in 1856 Le Mesurier, a railway engineer, had found a small chert arrowhead near Nyagurhee in central India, and in 1842 Dr Primrose had reported implements at Lingsugur. Foote's find, however, was the one that was followed up.
- He travelled to England in 1868 to inform the scholarly community of his work, and in 1873 some of the tools he had discovered were displayed at the International Exhibition at Vienna, so that within two decades the foundations of Indian prehistory had been laid and internationally recognised.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Patne

Maharashtra

ALSO: MESOLITHIC



LOCATION Patne, Jalgaon district, Maharashtra, in the Tapi valley.

PERIOD/LEVEL A stratigraphic sequence of Middle Palaeolithic, Upper Palaeolithic and Mesolithic tools; the ostrich eggshell from the Upper Palaeolithic level is dated to about 25,000 BP.

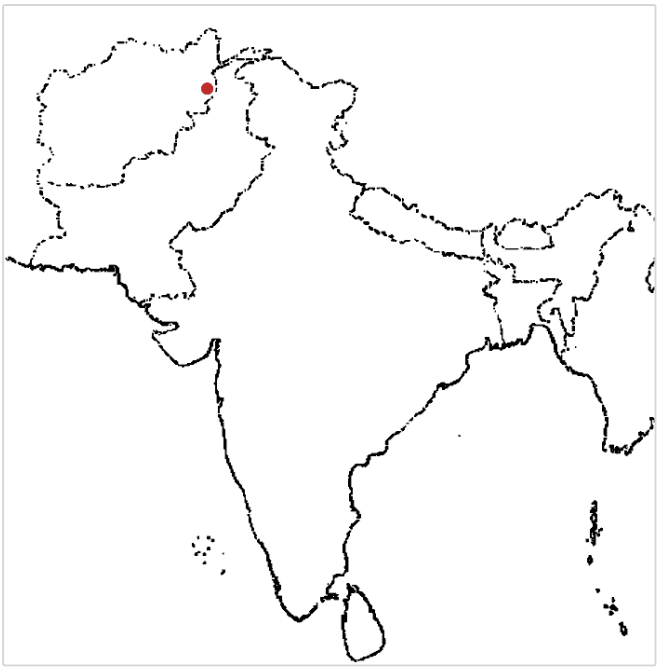
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Patne is the single most important Indian site for Upper Palaeolithic art and personal ornament.

- A piece of ostrich eggshell engraved with two panels of criss-cross designs was recovered here. Most patterned eggshell fragments from India turn out under the microscope to be naturally weathered; the Patne fragment is clearly engraved by human hands.
- Four perforated beads and one incomplete bead of ostrich eggshell, about 10 mm in diameter, came from the Upper Palaeolithic level. Such beads are known from about 41 Indian sites in Pleistocene contexts ranging from 39,000 to 25,000 BP, and from Siberia, inner Mongolia, China and Africa, linking India to a wider Upper Palaeolithic world of bead-making.
- A gradual reduction in tool size can be traced here from the late Pleistocene onwards, with microliths of that age, documenting the technological drift from the Upper Palaeolithic into the Mesolithic.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Peshawar

Pakistan



LOCATION The Peshawar valley, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Pakistan; the principal site is the Sanghao cave in the hills of the adjoining Mardan district.

PERIOD/LEVEL Middle and Upper Palaeolithic; occupation is commonly cited at about 30,000 years ago, with radiocarbon dates from Sanghao ranging from 41,825 +/- 4,120 BCE to 20,660 +/- 360 BCE.

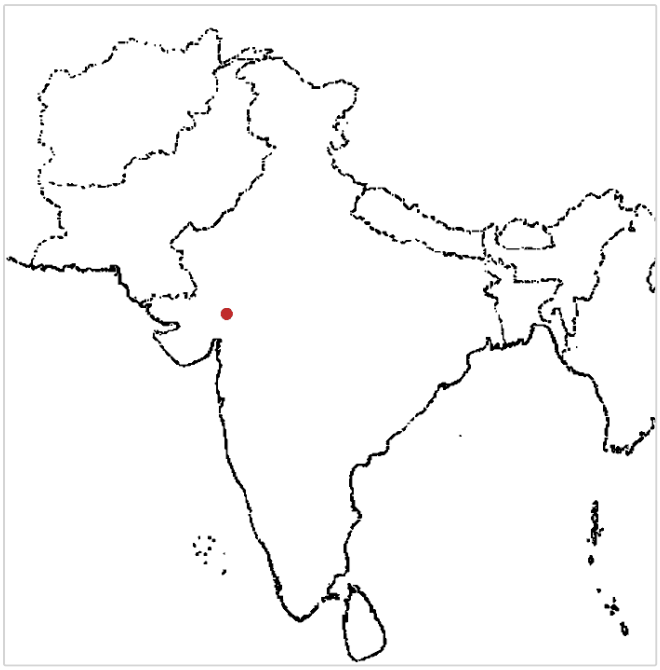
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Sanghao provides the best stratified cave sequence for the Middle and Upper Palaeolithic in the north-west of the subcontinent.

- The deposit is over 3 m thick and yielded thousands of stone tools, including chipped stone, scrapers, blades and flakes, almost all made of quartz that is easily available around the site.
- Hearths were found along with bones of animals and some possibly of humans, and with what appear to be burials, pointing to organised and repeated cave habitation.
- Peshawar, as ancient Purushapura, later became the Kushana capital, where Kanishka I is said to have enshrined the Buddha's relics in a stupa that became the centre of a major monastery.

SOURCES *Satish Chandra, Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I; Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century; J. L Mehta, Advanced Study in the History of Medieval India, Vol. I*

Sabarmati Valley

Gujarat



LOCATION The Sabarmati valley of north Gujarat, together with its Orsang and Karjan tributaries, and the related Bhadar valley in Saurashtra.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic, continuing into later phases.

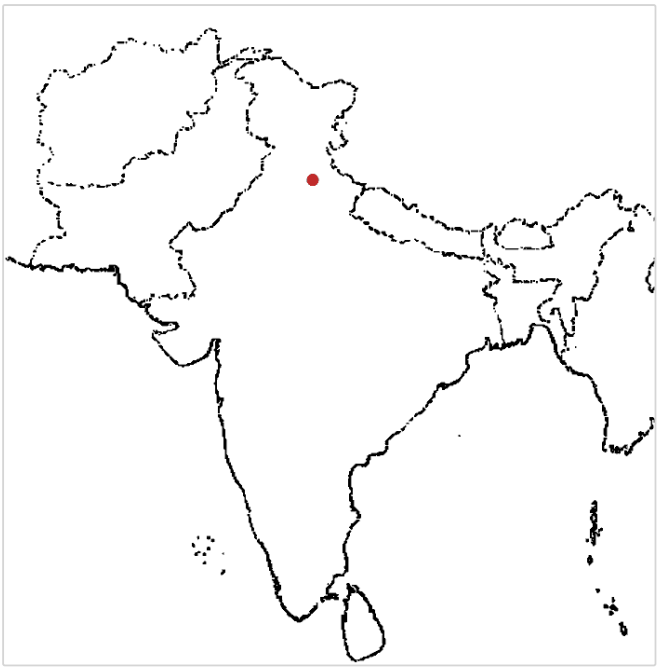
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE Lower Palaeolithic tools have been found throughout these valleys, establishing the Pleistocene occupation of Gujarat and bridging the Thar sites of Rajasthan with the Narmada sequence of central India.

- Lower Palaeolithic and later artefacts have also been found all along the Konkan coast as far as Goa, so the Gujarat valleys form the northern end of a continuous western Indian record.
- The same valley system later carried the important Mesolithic settlement of Langhnaj, giving the region a sequence from the Palaeolithic into the microlithic and Chalcolithic phases.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2*

Shivalik

Himachal Pradesh



LOCATION The Siwalik or Shivalik range, the outermost range of the Himalayas; the Himachal Pradesh sector centres on Suketi in Sirmaur district, with related evidence from the Jammu section.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic. Stone tools at Gurha Sahan and PS-57 are embedded in the Pinjor beds of the Siwaliks, dated between 2.4 and 2 million years ago, and at Uttarbaini in the Jammu area early Palaeolithic tools were found in a deposit dated 2.8 +/- 0.5 million years ago.

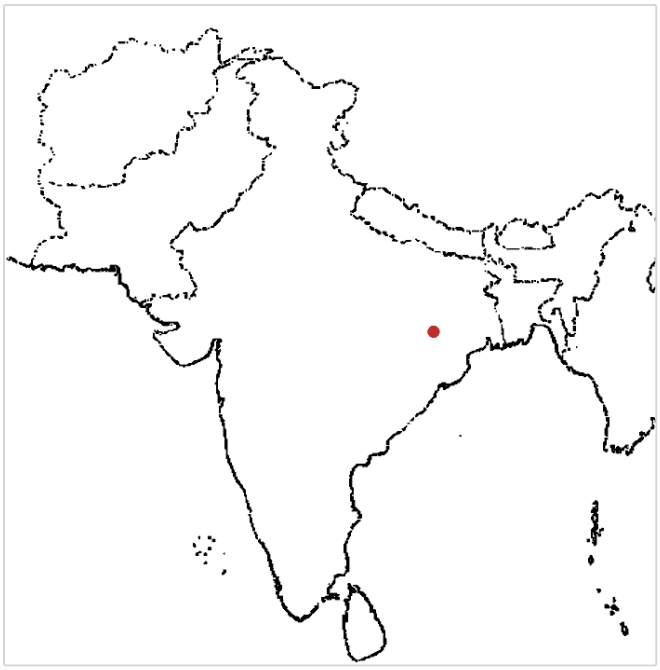
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The Siwaliks supply the greatest claimed time-depth for stone tools anywhere in the subcontinent, though these very early dates remain debated.

- Prehistoric vertebrate fossils and skeletons have been recovered from the geological formations of sandstone and clay at Suketi, the site of India's fossil park.
- From the nineteenth century onwards the range yielded remains of fossil apes named Ramapithecus, Sivapithecus and Brahmapithecus, collectively the "God-Apes of the Siwaliks", dated between 10 and 14 million years ago. Ramapithecus, of the Miocene-Pliocene transition, was once thought to be the oldest direct ancestor of modern humans, a view since abandoned on the basis of new dating methods and a reassessment of the fossils.

SOURCES *Upinder Singh, ch. 2 (the Suketi fossil park is from the author's notes)*

Singhbhum

Jharkhand



LOCATION Singhbhum district, on the Chhotanagpur plateau of Jharkhand, in the Subarnarekha basin.

PERIOD/LEVEL Lower Palaeolithic, with continuity of occupation in the region into the Neolithic and Chalcolithic phases.

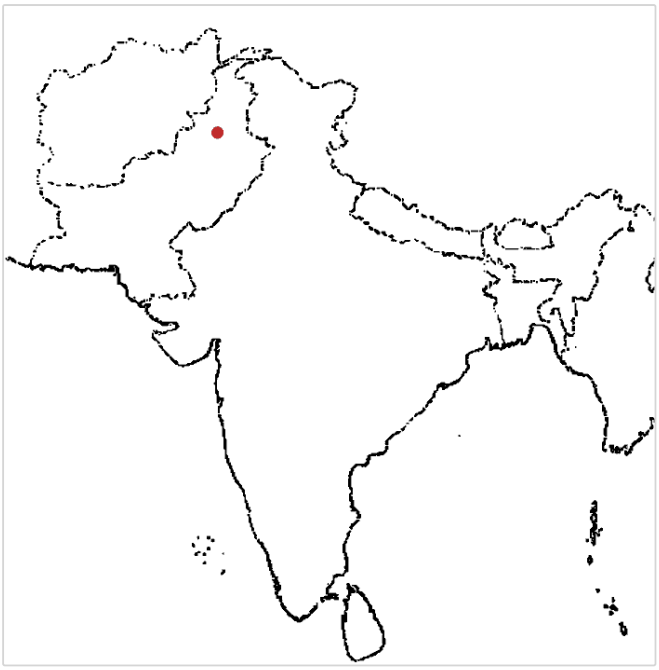
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The river valleys and foothills of the Chhotanagpur plateau and the adjoining areas of West Bengal have yielded Lower Palaeolithic tools, including handaxes and bifacial chopping tools.

- Barudih in the same district represents the later Neolithic-Chalcolithic occupation, with cultivated pulses such as chickpea, green pea and horse gram and an increase in faunal remains, showing unbroken use of the landscape.
- Singhbhum holds the richest copper mines in India, in a belt about 130 km long, which supplied the copper used by Chalcolithic and Harappan-period cultures, so the district connects the Palaeolithic occupation of eastern India to the metal-using cultures that followed.

SOURCES *R. S Sharma, India's Ancient Past; Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Sohan Valley

Pakistan



LOCATION The Soan or Sohan river in the Potwar plateau, between the Pir Panjal and the Salt ranges, in the Punjab province of Pakistan.

PERIOD/LEVEL The Soanian pebble tool tradition of the Lower Palaeolithic, contemporary with the Acheulian, with abundant Middle and Upper Palaeolithic material; Riwat near Rawalpindi has given a palaeomagnetic date of 2.01 million years ago, Dina and Jalalpur in the Jhelum basin about 700,000-500,000 years ago, and site 55 at Riwat 45,000 BP for the Upper Palaeolithic.

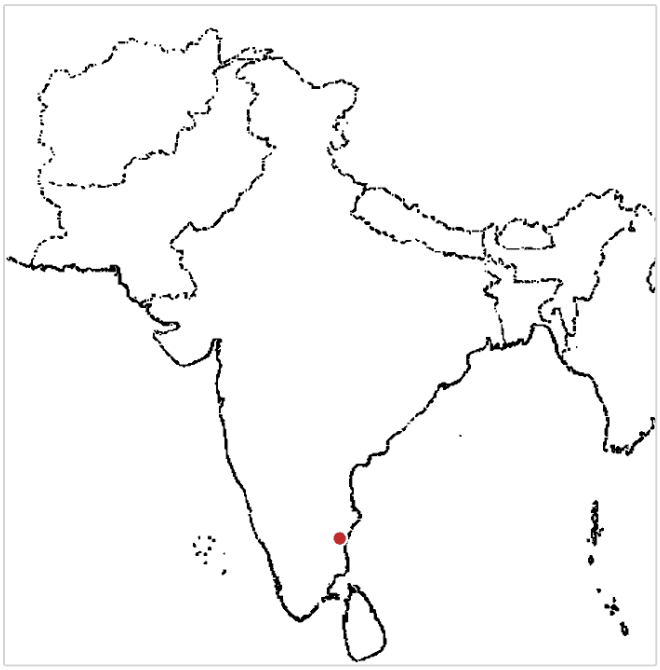
KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The type region of the Soanian industry and the setting of the first systematic palaeo-environmental study in Indian prehistory.

- In 1935 H. de Terra and T. T. Paterson found a large number of tools here, mostly of the Middle and Upper Palaeolithic with some of the Lower Palaeolithic, and identified five tool-bearing river terraces. The assemblage is dominated by choppers, chopping tools and edged pebble tools rather than handaxes.
- They tried to correlate these terraces with a four-fold glacial cycle in Kashmir and further with a four-fold European glacial cycle, and extended the framework to the Narmada and the area around Chennai. Most of their correlations and conclusions are no longer accepted, but the study marked an important stage in the development of Indian prehistoric research.
- Fossils of gazelle, rhinoceros, crocodile and giraffe from the region help reconstruct the Pleistocene environment of the north-west.

SOURCES *R. S Sharma, India's Ancient Past; Upinder Singh, A History of Ancient and Early Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century*

Tiruvakkarai

Tamil Nadu



LOCATION Tiruvakkarai, Villupuram district, Tamil Nadu, about 20 km from Puducherry, the site of the National Fossil Wood Park.

PERIOD/LEVEL Palaeolithic surface finds within a Miocene fossil-bearing formation.

KEY FINDS & SIGNIFICANCE The locality is best known for petrified wood fossils roughly 20 million years old, the trunks being thought to have been transported here by water before they were petrified.

- Palaeolithic tools occur in the same tract as neighbouring Odai, whose hominid remains and microliths make this stretch of the South Pennar basin one of the richest prehistoric landscapes in Tamil Nadu.
- The juxtaposition of a Miocene fossil bed with Palaeolithic occupation makes the site a convenient illustration of the difference between geological and archaeological time scales.

SOURCES *Geological Survey of India, National Fossil Wood Park, Tiruvakkarai, a National Geological Monument since 1951; the Palaeolithic finds are from the author's notes*